

C12 Over-Communication and Information Fatigue

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	35-45 minutes	Group Size	4-15
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	C1 (Communication Audit) recommended	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Information overload signals, feeling overwhelmed, productivity drops, decision-making delays, attention fragmentation

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain's attention system is a limited resource. Each notification, email, message, and meeting draws from the same pool of cognitive energy. Research on attention residue (Leroy, 2009) shows that switching between information sources leaves a cognitive 'residue' that impairs performance on the next task for up to 15 minutes.

Information fatigue is not about volume alone. It is about relevance filtering. The brain must evaluate every incoming message for relevance before it can decide to ignore or engage with it. When the ratio of relevant to irrelevant information drops, the brain spends more energy filtering than working. This is metabolically expensive: the brain uses roughly 20% of the body's energy, and attention management consumes a disproportionate share of that.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Information Audit (10 minutes)

Each person reviews their communication from the past 48 hours and categorises every message they received:

- Essential: needed this to do my job today
- Useful: good to know, but not time-sensitive
- Noise: did not need this, added no value to my work

Calculate the percentages. Most teams find 30-50% falls into the Noise category. Display the aggregate numbers. The visual impact of seeing "40% of our communication is noise" is powerful.

Phase 2: Source Analysis (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Where is the noise coming from? Not who is sending it. What channels, what types of messages, what patterns? And here's the harder question: where are YOU the source of noise for someone else?"

Map noise sources: reply-all culture, FYI emails with no clear action, Slack channels with too many people, meetings that could have been emails, status updates that nobody reads.

Phase 3: The Three Rules (10 minutes)

The team agrees on three communication rules designed to reduce noise:

Suggested starting points (the team can modify or replace):

8. Before sending, ask: "Does this person need this information to do their job today?" If not, don't send it.
9. Every message must have a clear action or a clear statement that no action is needed. ("FYI, no action required" is a valid and useful prefix.)
10. One channel per conversation. If it starts in Slack, it stays in Slack. If it moves to email, the Slack thread gets a link and closes.

Phase 4: The Quiet Experiment (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"For the next week, let's run an experiment. Everyone applies the three rules. At the end of the week, we'll check: did the volume of noise drop? Did anyone miss information they needed? Did productivity feel different? We'll adjust the rules based on what we learn."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	The noise percentage surprises people The team identifies specific, addressable noise sources The three rules feel actionable, not aspirational
Within 1 week	Email or message volume drops measurably Someone prefixes a message with 'FYI, no action required' A meeting is cancelled or shortened because the information can be communicated in writing
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Information overload signals decrease Productivity-related indicators improve Qualitative data references clarity, focus, or reduced noise

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C1: Communication Audit	C1 maps all channels; C12 focuses specifically on reducing noise within them.	Run C1 before C12
C13: Asynchronous Communication	Async teams are particularly vulnerable to information fatigue because there's no natural filtering mechanism like a meeting closing.	Complementary
E9: Removing Outdated Processes	Information fatigue often stems from process-driven communication that nobody has questioned. E9 removes those processes.	Complementary